The army's prolonged involvement in FATA and Swat created fears that Pashtun ethnic sentiment and religious sensibilities might affect the armed forces, as they are made up of 20 per cent Pashtun soldiers and officers. However, these apprehensions were unfounded and little credible evidence became known to suggest that the military was plagued with these problems (*Foreign Affairs*, 2009). There were no reported cases of insubordination or disobedience on these bases during the military operations in FATA and earlier in Swat. The Pakistan Army is considered a disciplined and professional organisation. The question whether a military method to quell insurgency and militancy is correct or not has already been discussed elsewhere.

The army is a professionally sound organisation that despite its multi-ethnic composition takes pride in its discipline. Anatol Lieven portrayed its nature in befitting words, 'It is the only Pakistani institution which works according to modern Weberian rules, as a more or less orderly, meritocratic and bureaucratic force with an esprit de corps and a capacity for self-discipline' (Lieven, 2007).

Nevertheless, the army's prolonged engagement in Waziristan, which resulted in collateral damage and inconvenience to the public, created bitter sentiments over the tough military methods. If the situation continued, the struggle against insurgents and terrorists might start losing its legitimacy and efficacy. Moreover, after the trans-border attacks by the Maulvi Fazlullah-led TTP terrorists from their hideouts in Afghanistan into Pakistan, it became all the more important for the army to focus on borders and let the trained para-military forces, especially trained for counter-insurgency in the FATA terrain handle the internal situation.

## THE USE OF LASHKARS TO COUNTER INSURGENTS

Even the use of 'lashkars' (tribal militias) against Taliban in FATA and Swat, encouraged by the army, required extra caution as it was likely to trigger inter-tribal strife and thus more violence (*Asia Times*, 16 July 2009). This was exactly what happened. The lashkars fizzled out in some areas; in others, they proved only partially effective (*Daily Times*, 2010). They also created confusion as it became difficult to differentiate between lashkars and terrorists. The confusion increased when the heads of the Taliban commanders claimed close terms with security forces.